

Skills Summary

Division: Group Size or Group Count?

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

Skill 1 — Sharing equally (find the group size)

Rule: $\text{total} \div \text{number of groups} = \text{number in each group}$.

The story gives you *how many groups*; your answer counts what lands in each one.

Example: 21 grapes are shared equally onto 3 plates. How many grapes on each plate?

Step 1. The 3 counts plates (groups), so divide the total by it to get the size of each share.

Step 2. $21 \div 3 = 7$, because $3 \times 7 = 21$.

$\Rightarrow$ 7 grapes on each plate

Try it: 32 crackers are shared equally onto 4 plates. How many crackers on each plate?

check: 8

Skill 2 — Making groups (find the group count)

Rule: $\text{total} \div \text{number in each group} = \text{number of groups}$.

The story gives you the *size* of a group; your answer counts how many groups you can make.

Example: 24 eggs are packed 6 to a carton. How many cartons are filled?

Step 1. The 6 is the size of each group, so divide the total by it to count the groups.

Step 2. $24 \div 6 = 4$, because $6 \times 4 = 24$.

$\Rightarrow$ 4 cartons

Try it: 45 bouncy balls are packed 9 to a bin. How many bins are filled?

check: 5

Skill 3 — Checking what your answer counts

Check yourself: After dividing, ask: *does my number count groups, or things in a group?*

If your answer is a number the story already gave you, you probably repeated a given instead of dividing.

Example: 36 pears are shared equally into 4 baskets. A student answers: “4 pears in each basket.” Fix it.

Step 1. The 4 is the number of baskets — a given, not the answer. The question asks for the size of each share, so divide.

Step 2. $36 \div 4 = 9$, because $4 \times 9 = 36$.

$\Rightarrow$ 9 pears in each basket, not 4

Try it: 40 stickers are shared equally onto 5 pages. A student answers “5 stickers per page.” What is the correct number per page?

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